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DUBAI

BY ANUPAM VARMA
News & Business Editor

As the first passenger train from Fujairah pulled into Abu Dhabi this morning, it wrote a new chapter for a country that has always put its people first. Not only has the high-speed train brought two of the farthest ends of the UAE closer, it has opened up countless doors to opportunities.

And it's only the beginning. On September 30, the Dubai station will become operational as well, bringing down the Dubai-Abu Dhabi journey to just 57 minutes. The Al Dhaid station will start operations on the same day. Meanwhile, the Al Dhafra station will be active starting December 30, while the Sharjah connection will start from March 30 next year.

The most immediate positive impact of the passenger service is the widening of the radius for both prospective employees and employers. At the same time, tourists on a short trip to the UAE will no longer have to choose between emirates.

Incredible savings

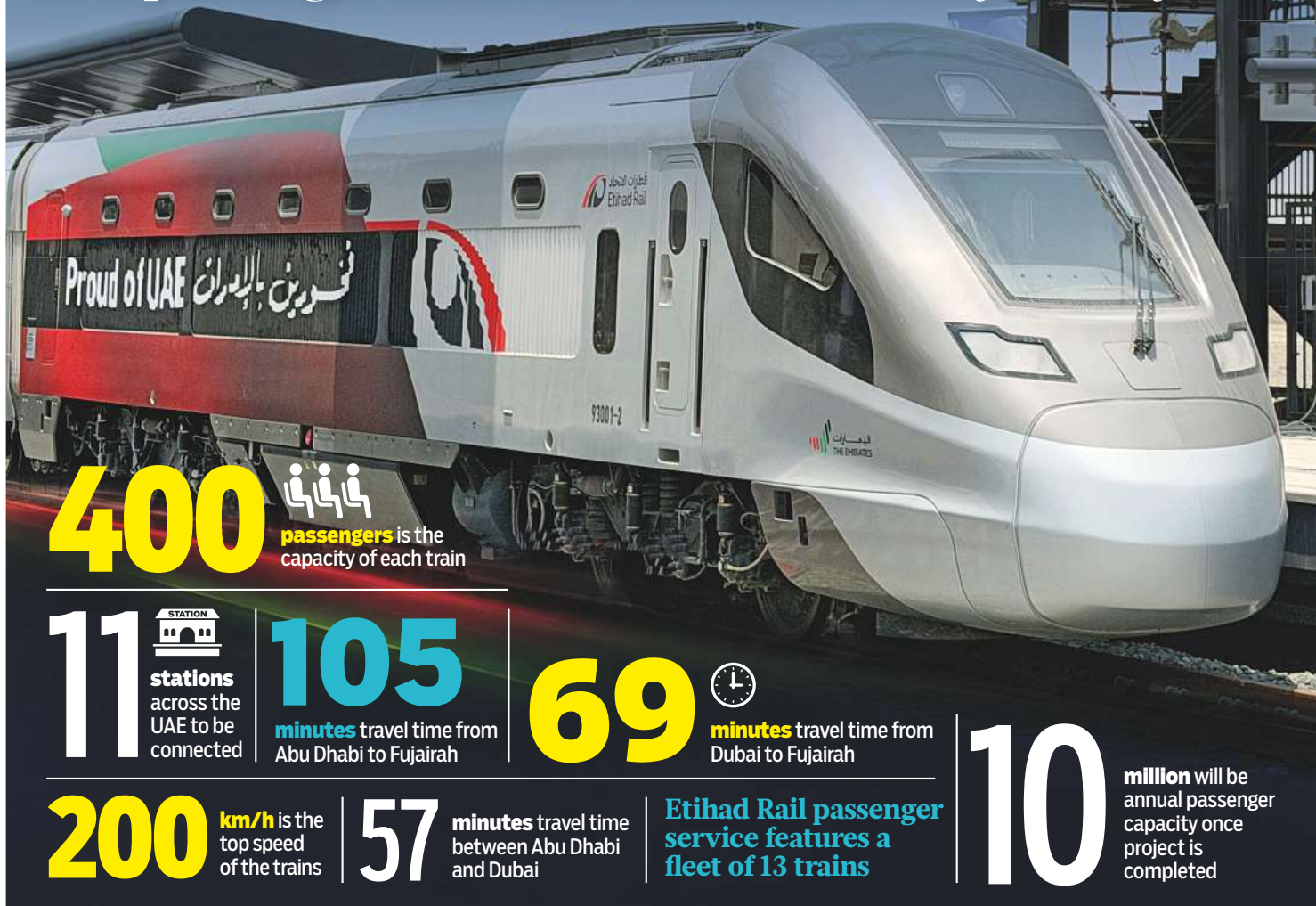
Combined with the goods services, the passenger trains will help cut carbon emissions drastically. Etihad Rail aims to transport 60 million tonnes of cargo annually by 2030, reducing road transport emissions by 21 per cent annually by 2050.

That would equate to taking 300 trucks off the roads for every train journey and eliminating 8.2 million tonnes of carbon dioxide annually. Once the passenger service connects all the stations, residents will see incredible savings in fuel bills as well as time spent on the road during peak hours.

"The passenger rail network marks a transformative milestone in the development of the UAE's national transport ecosystem by harnessing the latest

A NEW DAWN FOR UAE

First passenger train rolls into Abu Dhabi from Fujairah



technologies and innovations to deliver an advanced mobility system that provides a modern, safe and highly efficient travel experience," Sheikh Theyab Bin Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Deputy Chairman of the Presidential Court for Development and Fallen Heroes'

Affairs and Chairman of Etihad Rail, said earlier this month.

"The network's multiple stations, together with their seamless integration with other means of transport, will enhance connectivity between cities and key destinations while providing passengers with more conveni-

ent and flexible travel options that meet the evolving needs of the community and support rapid urban development across the UAE," he added.

The launch of passenger rail services comes less than five years after the UAE announced its vision for developing the

UAE railway programme, which includes the passenger train project, as part of the Projects of the 50 in 2021.

The Etihad Rail passenger service features a fleet of 13 trains, each with a capacity of up to 400 passengers.

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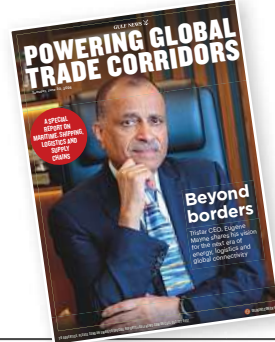
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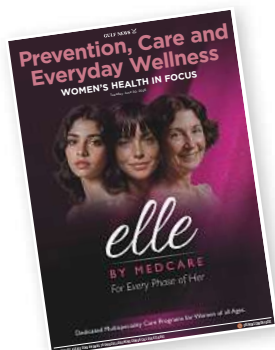
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Trump says Iran has requested fresh talks

Tehran says no new negotiations scheduled

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump said yesterday that Iran had requested fresh talks with Washington and that a meeting would take place in Doha today, even as a senior Iranian negotiator denied that any new negotiations had been scheduled after renewed military exchanges threatened the fragile truce.

Trump said on social media that his special envoy Steve Witkoff and son-in-law Jared Kushner would travel to Qatar for the meeting. However, Iran's senior negotiator, Kazem Gharibabadi, dismissed reports of technical talks, saying no such meeting had been confirmed.

The conflicting claims came after four days of strikes in and around the Strait of Hormuz cast fresh doubt on the interim US-Iran agreement reached earlier this month. While both sides appeared to pause attacks yesterday, tensions remained

high after Iran targeted commercial vessels in the strategic waterway and launched drone and missile attacks on Bahrain and Kuwait. The United States responded with strikes on Iranian coastal targets. Iran and Oman also held their first meeting yesterday to discuss the future management of the Strait of Hormuz, a key element of the interim agreement.

Frozen assets release

Meanwhile, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said Qatar would release \$6 billion in frozen Iranian assets under the deal, describing it as "a great victory for the Iranian people". Neither Washington nor Doha confirmed the transfer.

Regional tensions remain high as Iran warned against the use of alternative shipping routes through the Strait of Hormuz, while Israel targeted Hezbollah tunnels in southern Lebanon. Separately, Qatar's Ministry of Transport announced a temporary suspension of marine activities involving recreational boats, fishing vessels, jet skis and similar watercraft until further notice, citing public safety.

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